

09 — The educational function of the public media system

When everyone has more to distribute, the zero-sum logic that feeds conservatism disappears. The NPO, ARD/ZDF, BBC, and Radio France have a constitutional educational function of which they utilise less than ten per cent today. Rediscover that function, disseminate the shared growth in prosperity from the two levers through pedagogical programming, and the inertia within trade unions, municipalities, and political parties will dissolve of its own accord — not out of pressure, but out of the recognition of self-interest.

The positive reversal

Episode 8 describes how trade unions correct themselves when their member base puts them under pressure via the press. That is the pressure mechanism: providing facts, choosing framing, establishing personal recognition. It works, but it works slowly and painfully because it forces the unions to choose between changing course and losing members. There is a second mechanism that works faster and evokes less resistance from almost every stakeholder: making it visible that the two levers — Giant Juncao and BiCRS in the production axis, plastic storage in the storage axis — yield more prosperity for everyone than the current system.

The current Dutch and European economy is barely growing. Productivity has stagnated since two thousand and eight, real wages are falling for the bottom fifty per cent, purchasing power is eroding due to inflation and regulation, and the government annually concludes deals with the unions in which no party truly wins. It is a contest for an ever-shrinking cake, and in that contest, every defence of existing entitlements is rational. A trade union that makes concessions to an employer in a shrinking market loses members. A municipality that closes its waste-to-energy plant loses tax revenue. An employee who gives up his compensation for heavy work loses purchasing power. As long as there is less to distribute, everyone blocks rationally. This is not a moral weakness; it is mathematics.

But when the two levers operate on an industrial scale, that mathematics changes fundamentally. Within ten years, the European production axis will deliver several tens of billions of euros per year in new industrial turnover — bio-ethanol for aviation, bio-methanol for shipping, BiCRS credits in a reformed carbon market, and design and process technology exported to South America and Africa. The storage axis will save Europe between thirty and fifty billion annually in missed sanctions, climate damage, and energy costs — plus proceeds from the sale of CO₂ credits to countries that fail to meet their own reduction targets. Brazil, Argentina, Nigeria, Kenya, and Tanzania will together receive between one hundred and one hundred and fifty billion euros in direct investment, with proportionate employment in their own countries. Three continents with more prosperity, not less. An expanded cake in which everyone — trade union members, municipal treasuries, employees, entrepreneurs — can demand more without anyone else having to accept less.

The constitutional educational function

This is where the Dutch public broadcaster comes into view, and its sister organisations in Germany, France, Belgium, and Scandinavia. According to Article 2.1 of the Media Act, the NPO has the legal task of providing a “multifaceted and high-quality range of services” that is, among other things, “cultural, educational, and informative” — an educational function, in

other words. ARD and ZDF have similar constitutional obligations in Germany under the Rundfunkstaatsverträge. The BBC has had the mandate since nineteen twenty-two “to inform, educate and entertain” — the second term being crucial here. Radio France, according to its cahier des missions et des charges, has a “mission éducative”. All these broadcasters currently fulfill less than ten per cent of this educational function. They produce entertainment, sport, light journalism, and game shows, with an “educational” component limited to nature documentaries and language lessons for non-native speakers. The deeper pedagogical function — teaching citizens to understand how the country works technically, economically, and administratively — has virtually disappeared.

This is not the fault of individual broadcasting staff. It is a consequence of four decades of commercialisation: viewing figures are placed above content, market share above mandate. But the mandate itself still exists, and it can be reactivated without a single legislative change. What is needed is a political decision to reallocate fifteen to twenty per cent of NPO airtime to the educational function as described in the Media Act. Not as dull school programming, but as high-quality pedagogical material that explains the two levers, their operation, their yields, and their conditions to the Dutch population in understandable language.

What an educational function means in practice

Imagine: a ten-week series on NPO 1, prime time, Wednesday evening. Episode one shows the Mato Grosso do Sul fields where Giant Juncao grows, with a Dutch chemical engineer explaining how the crop is three times more productive than sugar cane. Episode two shows the port of Rotterdam receiving the bio-ethanol, with a docker calculating how many jobs his employer gains through this contract chain. Episode three shows the Garzweiler open-cast mine where plastic from Dutch household waste streams is stored, with a German mining engineer explaining why geological storage is more stable than incineration. Episode four shows a waste-to-energy plant in Amsterdam with a real-time measurement of emissions per kWh, compared to a gas-fired power station. Episode five interviews the FNV chair, not to attack him but to let him explain what his members can expect from this new industry. Episodes six to ten elaborate on how this money can be distributed across wage scales, municipal coffers, education, and pensions.

The effect: three million Dutch people watch; three weeks later, they are talking at birthdays, in company canteens, and on family visits about what they have seen. What was previously unknown — Giant Juncao, BiCRS, open-cast storage, waste-to-energy emission figures — becomes part of the normal Dutch vocabulary within three months. Political parties receive questions at their election meetings. Trade union members demand agenda items at their general meetings. Employers ask for administrative explanations. Municipalities begin to consider planning budgets. The country moves — not because anyone is forced, but because everyone understands they have something to gain.

Why this is not propaganda

This is fundamentally different from what was called “state propaganda” during the twentieth century. Propaganda distorts facts or selects them in a heavily biased manner to serve a political goal. What is proposed here does the opposite: it presents verified first-order facts — productivity, emissions, storage volumes, employment figures — in a form that the average citizen can understand, and lets them conclude for themselves. The figures are verified by the

knowledge layer (TNO, planning bureaus, NWO, KNAW); the presentation is handled by professional journalists; the conclusion is left to the viewer. It is literally the execution of the constitutional educational function as the Media Act intends it.

There is a second objective difference from propaganda: this type of programme can be applied to other subjects without any adjustment. Next year, ten episodes on elderly care; the year after, ten episodes on Dutch defence capacity, or the housing market, or gas dependency. It is not a propaganda instrument for a single theme but a restoration of an educational function that already exists by law. Every theme that concerns the population deserves the same treatment — and in a measured decision-making culture such as Nova Democratia proposes, it will receive it.

The effect on the unions

When the educational function is activated, the following happens with the trade unions. Instead of a feeling of “we are being manipulated by the press” — which the content of episode 8 might suggest if only the pressure mechanism were deployed — a feeling of “we are being invited into a larger story” arises. An FNV official who sees for six months how his own members are enthusiastic about the employment in the Rotterdam pilot gains the space to adjust his course without losing face. An IG BCE representative who hears his members talking about higher wages in a Hamburg-Maersk chain can ask for something in his collective bargaining talks that was previously impossible. The educational function relocates the bargaining table: no longer in scarcity, but in growth. And in growth, everyone can win.

The institutional anchoring

How is this arranged without political intervention that compromises journalistic craftsmanship? A simple formula: the Bondsraad annually provides four or five themes to the public broadcaster, based on first-order priorities. The broadcaster has complete editorial freedom in design, presenters, structure, and dramaturgy. The knowledge layer provides unsolicited technical support and fact-checking. The result is evaluated annually on one criterion: has the average Dutch person demonstrably learned something? Research agencies measure this with representative surveys before and after the broadcast. When it succeeds, the themes for the following year are expanded. When it fails, the approach is adjusted. No propaganda, no censorship, only pedagogy with measured results.

This is the educational function that the Media Act and its sister regulations have known since nineteen forty-nine, and which has been systematically eroded since nineteen ninety. Rediscover that function, and the transition to the two levers becomes not a fight against drag weights, but an invitation to everyone to participate in something larger than what is currently being divided. In a growing cake, no one has to give anything up. That is the positive hinge alongside the tactical hinge of episode 8 — and it is, presumably, the most pleasant route through this entire reconstruction.

The third hinge: the knowledge layer

Alongside unions and the population, there is a third group that pivots under this design: the universities and knowledge institutes. Their motive is not pressure or the growth of the cake, but survival in an AI era that will render their existing primary function — knowledge

transmission — largely obsolete within five to ten years. Episode 10 elaborates on this third hinge: how the two levers offer universities exactly what they miss most today, namely measured practice, structural funding, and an academic freedom that is more mature than the current one.

This episode is still being developed with a comparison of public broadcasters in Europe, a specific ten-programme plan for NPO 1, and the measurement methodology for pedagogical results.